

Past Imperfect

Presenting an Anglo-centric view, Spilsbury fails to dwell on the background to the First War of Indian Independence



THE INDIAN MUTINY
by JULIAN SPILSBURY
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■ By Gillian Wright

One hundred and fifty years after what we now know as the First War of Indian Independence must be an appropriate time to reassess it. What was then known as "The Mutiny" was suppressed, but the fear that entered the psyche of the British in India from that time always remained. It was this fear that in part led to, and certainly justified, the Jallianwala Bagh massacre, which was the spur to Indian Independence.

However, Julian Spilsbury's *The Indian Mutiny* is not that reassessment. Instead, it is curiously anachronistic. Throughout, Kanpur is referred to as Cawnpore (even when describing the city as it is today), Avadh as Oude and Indians all too often as "natives". His book is generally on the lines of Christopher Hibbert's *The Great Mutiny*, but Spilsbury selects different passages from many of the same British eyewitness accounts. He appears to make no effort to see which ones may have embroidered the facts, as many may have done after the war was won and the Mutiny myths grew. Neither does he make any great effort to examine sources in languages besides English. The poet Ghalib's Persian diary of Delhi in 1857-8, written to be presented to Queen Victoria, is one example of a contemporary record easily available.

Most of the stories of the uprising and its brutal suppression are so cruel that to read them is to be reminded of the appalling nature of war. Spilsbury, like many of the new generation of popular historians, vividly recreates the scenes he describes. However,

while he criticises the Company bahadur's running of its army and affairs, his description of the background to the uprising is somewhat brief. There could have been more to say, for example, about how the British made a total hash of managing Avadh after annexation in 1856. They disbanded tens of thousands of troops but let them keep their weapons, put thousands of civilian contractors and court attendants out of work, demolished homes, public buildings and a luxury market. They knocked down a Hindu temple and used a revered Muslim shrine as a powder magazine. They arrested the

DISORIENTED: Indian soldiers were torn between loyalty and patriotism



editor of an Urdu newspaper—causing a major outcry—and went on to impose higher taxes on opium, dispossess taluqdars and order them to surrender the war-like stores in their forts. The much-maligned Wajid Ali Shah was allowed to spend three weeks in Kanpur on his way to Calcutta to argue his case, becoming a symbol of Indian

humiliation. Even the sepoys in the British forces, mainly from peasant families, lost the privileges they had as long as Avadh was, in theory, an independent kingdom. In short, practically every segment of Avadh society was alienated. The main recruiting ground for the sepoy army was Avadh. It naturally became the key to the revolt and every symbol of foreign rule there was targeted.

Spilsbury does demonstrate how Indian soldiers were sometimes torn between personal loyalty to their officers and rejection of foreign rule. He documents many occasions when Indian staff saved British men, women and children at great personal risk to themselves. However, while he appreciates the charisma and leadership of officers such as Nicholson, who led the storming of Delhi's Kashmiri Gate in 1858, leaders like the Rani of Jhansi, Begum Hazrat Mahal and Nana Sahib are not shown so sympathetically. This is largely due to the lack of Indian input to the book.

In the end, the uprising never posed a direct threat to Calcutta, the heart of British power, or to the Madras or Bombay presidencies. The Sikhs stood by the British and the British won back power with Indian help. Spilsbury admits that this need not have happened if the commanders of the anti-British forces had been more coordinated and had adopted a better strategy. He unflinchingly documents many atrocities and shows how some British officers were horrified by the vengeful acts of their colleagues, and how Henry Lawrence of Punjab pressed for them to be stopped. But surely the days have passed for such an old-fashioned, Anglo-centric view of a largely Indian event. This anniversary deserves a more fitting tribute to the thousands upon thousands of people who were the victims of this conflict. ■